

■ By Damayanti Datta

**W**hat unites India? Mindless eating, says a new survey. In a country where everyone has an opinion—where we celebrate the idea of unity without uniformity and diversity without fragmentation—putting food in our mouth without thinking is what holds us together. To capture the spirit of the nation through its stomach, market research company, AC Nielsen, surveyed over 1,000 households across

the five metros of Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, Bangalore and Chennai this month. The results provide new food for thought: urban Indians are clearly eating with their eyes and not the stomach; they think they eat healthy, but actually pig out on unwholesome fare; they know what makes healthy food, but opt for junk grub. In all, the identity marker in today's urban India is a simple question: "How many meals do you eat in a day?"

Ask Ashok Anand. The 54-year-old resident of Noida has chomped on food throughout the day all his life. "I've always loved food," he explains. Apart from three square meals—breakfast, lunch and dinner—he would consume endless cups of tea and coffee and snack through the day: midmorning biscuits, teatime samosas, predinner fritters, postdinner ice-creams. Sometimes alone, sometimes with family, friends and guests. His best-loved hour was before dinner, when he stuffed himself with kebabs and tikkas, to complement his peg of whiskey. No wonder, he bust the scales at 100 kg one day. Finally, dogged with diabetes, he trudged off to see the doctor.

Anand would be surprised to know that he is more standard than exception in today's metro India. On the face of it, most survey respondents claim to have regular, timely and home-cooked meals. But scratch below the surface. They are eating at all times and through the day—as many as seven meals. Over 50 per cent consume four unhealthy snacks in-between meals and at irregular hours. Of these, the highest proportion is glutted before dinner: over 62 per cent snack predinner and for 90 per cent they consist of pakodas, noodles, burgers, pizzas, chat, biscuits and chips; although 72 per cent cite fruits as the most nutritious food, they munch on biscuits through the day; 62 per cent mention fast, convenient food as "ideal snacks".

"In 60 years of Independence, no matter how tuned in we think we are to our eating habits, we have turned into a nation of mindless eaters," asserts Dr K.S. Reddy, former head of cardiology and now director, Public Health Foundation of India. Food and the culture of eating well have always been vital in India, but until recently most ate home-cooked meals, with families, and at a leisurely pace. "A hundred years ago there was no such thing as a snack food—nothing you could pop open and overeat. People ate ample amounts of fresh fruits and vegetables," adds Reddy, a member of the World Health Organisation expert consultation on diet, nutrition and prevention of chronic diseases. Moreover, low-technology lifestyles necessitated vastly more physical activity. "Our grandparents moved all day long—not jogging for an hour—but

Photographs by HEMANT CHAWLA  
Photo imaging by VADHU BHASKAR

## UNHAPPY MEALS

Over 90% in Delhi and Mumbai eat healthy. Bangalore, Kolkata and Chennai average a poor 23%.

